Good and Bad Practice of Presenting Results

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2026

Bad Example: Language Problems

Q3 Sales Performance

- We done real good this quarter
- Revenue went up alot
- Customer satisfaction is better
- The numbers look pretty nice
- We should probably do more of what we did

Thing	Amount
Sales	$1.2M
Costs	$800K
Profit	$400K

Language Problems Identified

- **Grammar errors:** "done real good", "went up alot"
- **Informal tone:** "pretty nice", "thing"
- **Vague modifiers:** "alot", "better", "probably"
- **Unprofessional headers:** "Thing" instead of metric name
- **Missing context:** No comparison to targets or prior periods
- **Weak verbs:** "went up" instead of "increased by X%"

Impact: Undermines credibility and confuses stakeholders.

Good Example: Professional Language

Q3 2024 Sales Performance

vs. Q3 2023 and Q3 Target

- Revenue increased 18% YoY to $1.24M (vs. $1.05M in Q3 2023)
- Gross profit margin improved from 28% to 32%
- Net Promoter Score rose 8 points to 62
- Exceeded quarterly revenue target by 6%

Metric	Q3 2024	Q3 2023	Target
Revenue	$1.24M	$1.05M	$1.17M
Gross Profit	$397K	$294K	$351K
Margin	32%	28%	30%

Professional Language Elements

- **Precise terminology:** "increased 18% YoY"
- **Comparative context:** Prior period and target included
- **Specific metrics:** NPS score, exact dollar amounts
- **Action verbs:** "increased", "improved", "exceeded"
- **Professional formatting:** Booktabs table, clear headers
- **Quantified claims:** Every statement has a number

Impact: Builds confidence and enables data-driven decisions.

Bad Example: Unsubstantiated Claims

Marketing Campaign Results

- Our campaign was super successful
- We have the best conversion rate in the industry
- Customers love our new approach
- This strategy always works
- We're definitely going to grow next quarter

Key Takeaway:
Everything is going great!

Claim Problems

- **"Super successful"** – No metrics, no benchmark
- **"Best in industry"** – No source or comparison data
- **"Customers love"** – Anecdotal, no survey data
- **"Always works"** – Absolute statement, no evidence
- **"Definitely going to grow"** – Prediction without basis

Why This Fails:

- Stakeholders cannot verify assertions
- No accountability for outcomes
- Appears defensive or evasive
- Decisions based on opinions, not facts

Good Example: Evidence-Based Claims

Marketing Campaign Results: Q3 Digital Push

- Campaign achieved 4.2% conversion rate (+0.8pp vs. Q2)
- Industry benchmark: 3.1% (Source: HubSpot 2024 Report)
- 87% of surveyed customers (n=450) rated experience 4+/5
- Similar campaigns in 2022–2023 averaged 3.5% conversion

Forecast: Q4 revenue projected at $1.35M (95% CI: $1.28M–$1.42M) based on current pipeline and historical close rates.

Metric	Result	Benchmark
Conversion Rate	4.2%	3.1% (industry)
ROAS	4.5x	3.2x (internal avg)
CAC	$45	$62 (Q2 2024)

Evidence-Based Elements

- **Specific metrics:** 4.2% with absolute change (+0.8pp)
- **Cited sources:** HubSpot report referenced
- **Sample sizes:** n=450 for customer feedback
- **Historical context:** 2022–2023 comparison provided
- **Confidence intervals:** Forecast with uncertainty range
- **Multiple benchmarks:** Industry + internal comparisons

Impact: Claims are verifiable, trustworthy, and actionable.

Bad Example: Vagueness & Lack of Specificity

Customer Churn Analysis

- We lost some customers this quarter
- Churn is higher than we'd like
- A few big accounts left
- The trend isn't great
- We need to fix retention soon

Churn by Segment:

SMB: Pretty high
Enterprise: Lower
Mid-Market: Medium

Vagueness Issues

- **"Some customers"** – How many? What %?
- **"Higher than we'd like"** – What's the target?
- **"A few big accounts"** – Revenue impact?
- **"Isn't great"** – Direction? Magnitude?
- **"Soon"** – Timeline undefined
- **"Pretty high/Medium"** – No quantification

Consequences:

- No sense of urgency or priority
- Cannot allocate resources effectively
- Leadership lacks information to act
- Team unsure what problem to solve

Good Example: Specificity & Precision

Customer Churn Analysis: Q3 2024

- Quarterly churn: 8.4% (vs. 5.2% target, 6.1% Q2)
- 12 customers churned (3 Enterprise, 9 SMB)
- Lost $340K ARR: $280K Enterprise, $60K SMB
- Churn rate trending upward for 3 consecutive quarters

Action Required: Reduce churn to <6% by Q4-end through retention program.

Specificity Elements

- **Exact percentages:** 8.4% with target and prior period
- **Absolute numbers:** 12 customers, $340K ARR
- **Segment breakdown:** Clear categorization
- **Trend identified:** 3 consecutive quarters
- **Specific timeline:** "by Q4-end"
- **Quantified goal:** Reduce to <6%

Impact: Clear problem definition enables targeted action.

Segment	Q3 Churn	Q2 Churn	Target	ARR Lost
Enterprise	4.2%	2.1%	2.0%	$280K
Mid-Market	7.1%	5.8%	4.5%	$0K
SMB	12.3%	9.4%	8.0%	$60K
Total	**8.4%**	**6.1%**	**5.2%**	**$340K**

Bad Example: No Call to Action

Supply Chain Analysis

- Inventory turnover is 4.2x annually
- Lead times from Supplier A average 14 days
- Stockout rate is 6% for critical items
- Warehousing costs increased 12% this year
- We have 3 main distribution centers

Summary:
This is our current supply chain situation.

[End of presentation]

Missing Elements

- **No decision requested:** What should leadership do?
- **No priorities:** Which issues matter most?
- **No options:** Are there alternatives to consider?
- **No resource ask:** Budget? Headcount? Time?
- **No timeline:** When do decisions need to be made?
- **No owner:** Who is responsible for next steps?

Result:

- Meeting ends without outcomes
- Analysis doesn't drive action
- Stakeholders confused about purpose
- Problem persists unaddressed

Good Example: Clear Call to Action

Supply Chain Optimization: Decision Required

Situation: Stockout rate (6%) exceeds target (3%), risking $2M in Q4 revenue.

Options Evaluated:

1. **Increase safety stock** – Reduces stockouts to 2%, adds $180K holding cost
2. **Dual-source critical items** – Reduces stockouts to 3%, adds $120K sourcing cost
3. **Status quo** – Risk of $2M revenue loss, customer churn

Recommended Action: Approve Option 2 (dual-sourcing) for top 20 SKUs.

Decision Required By: September 15 to implement by Q4.

Budget Request: $120K (ROI: 17x based on revenue protection)

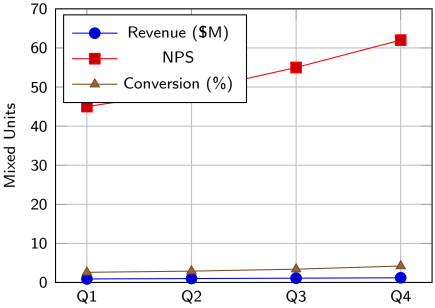
Call to Action Elements

- **Clear framing:** "Decision Required" in title
- **Risk quantified:** $2M revenue at stake
- **Options presented:** Three choices with trade-offs
- **Recommendation made:** Specific option chosen
- **Deadline set:** September 15 for Q4 readiness
- **Resources specified:** $120K budget with ROI
- **Scope defined:** Top 20 SKUs only

Impact: Stakeholders have everything needed to decide immediately.

Bad Example: Results Visualization Without Context

Quarterly Performance Overview



Q4 looks higher than Q1, so all metrics appear to be improving.

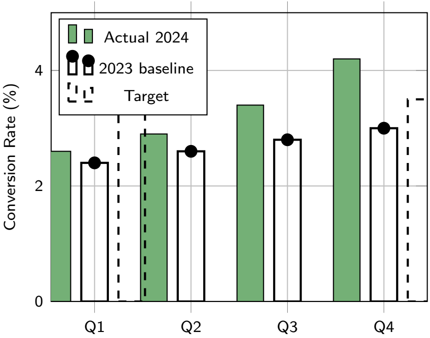
Visualization Problems

- Different units plotted on one axis
- Revenue trend is visually flattened
- No benchmark or target shown
- No takeaway tied to a decision
- Legend forces audience to decode chart
- Generic conclusion adds no insight

Impact: The chart is technically true, but visually misleading and hard to interpret.

Good Example: Results Visualization With Context

Conversion Rate Improved Above Benchmark



Takeaway: Q4 conversion reached **4.2%**, exceeding the **3.5% target** and outperforming the **3.0% prior-year baseline**.

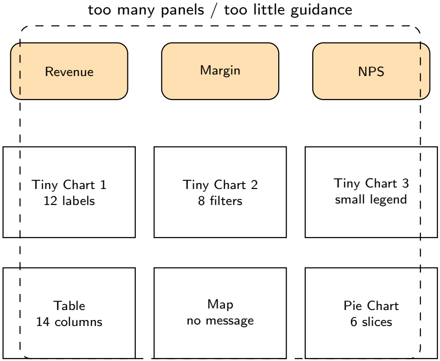
What Makes This Better

- One decision-relevant metric per chart
- Prior year and target give context
- Title communicates the conclusion
- Scale matches the metric being shown
- Chart and takeaway tell one story
- Supports a concrete business claim

Impact: Stakeholders can immediately see performance, context, and implication.

Bad Example: Dashboard-Style Result Dump

Monthly Business Review Dashboard



Audience must decide for themselves what matters.

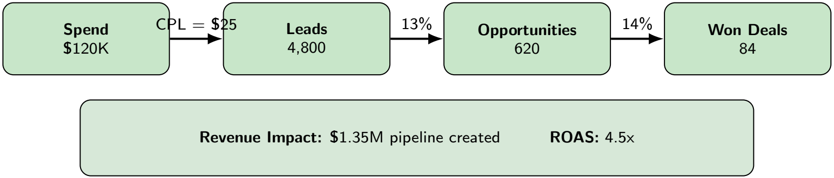
Why This Fails

- Too many panels competing for attention
- Small charts are unreadable in a room
- No narrative or prioritization
- Decorative visuals add clutter
- No decision, owner, or next step
- Looks analytical, but does not communicate

Impact: Viewers scan everything and remember nothing.

Good Example: Result Story With Flow and Action

Campaign Funnel: Spend to Revenue



Recommended Action: Increase budget 15% for the highest-converting channel and pause the lowest-ROI segment.

Why This Works

Impact: Results are easy to follow, remember, and act on.

- Shows the logic from input to outcome
- Each stage uses a clear business metric
- Final box highlights the executive result
- Recommendation is tied directly to evidence
- Easy to explain verbally in under 30 seconds
- Supports decision-making, not just reporting